



LEARNING JOURNEY - EPISODE 016

Small steps: The spill is not the child

A gentle practice for the next pressured moment.

Parent practice workbook

Episode 016

6 pages



You do not need a perfect sentence. This workbook helps you notice the pressure, keep what matters and prepare one phrase you can actually use.

Production resource - adapt to the child, setting, culture, access needs and safety context.



01 - START WITH THE ADULT WEATHER

What was I carrying into the moment?

Pressure can explain why words came out sharply. It does not make the child responsible for the adult's feelings.

THE MOMENT

What happened? Keep it short and observable.



MY PRESSURE

What else was I carrying - time, noise, worry, mess, tiredness or something different?

WHAT I SAID

Write the words without editing them. This is information, not a verdict on you.

A useful pause

The moment was hard. I can still choose what I say next.



02 - MOVE FROM PRESSURE TO USEFUL INFORMATION

Name the moment without defining the child.

Specific words help everyone understand what happened, what must remain and where to begin.

ORIGINAL MOMENT

"You're so careless."

USEFUL NEXT SENTENCE

"The mess still needs to be cleaned. First, describe what happened and begin the clean-up."

WHAT A CAMERA COULD RECORD

Write only what could be seen or heard.

WHAT STILL MATTERS

Name the responsibility, safety need, limit, learning goal or practical next step.

Episode principle

Separate responsibility for an event from a judgement about identity.



03 - NOTICE POSSIBLE WEATHER

What might the words have communicated?

You cannot read a child's mind. Use possibilities, then stay open to what the child shows or tells you.



One possible feeling



Another possibility



Weather can change

Illustrations show possible momentary emotions, not fixed traits or diagnoses.

MY GENTLE GUESS

The child may, might or could have heard: Young children may hear a pressured sentence as a message about who they are. Keep the language short, concrete and close to the next action.

WHAT I CAN CHECK

What could I notice or ask without demanding an answer?



04 - KEEP WHAT MATTERS

Warm and firm can sit together.

The aim is not instant happiness or cooperation. The aim is clear information, dignity and a usable next action.

Episode example

"The mess still needs to be cleaned. First, describe what happened and begin the clean-up."



PAUSE

What does the moment require?

DESCRIBE

What specific information can I give?

KEEP

What boundary, responsibility or safety need remains?

NEXT

What is one action or real question to begin?

MY WHOLE NEXT SENTENCE

Put the useful parts together in words that sound like you.



05 - REPAIR AND REPEAT

A hard moment can still have a next chapter.

Repair owns the adult's delivery, restates what matters and makes room to try again. It does not ask the child to comfort the adult.

A simple repair

"I said that sharply. I want to try again. The mess still needs to be cleaned. First, describe what happened and begin the clean-up."



MY REPAIR WORDS

Own the delivery, keep what matters and offer the next step.

One-week practice tracker

	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
Paused	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Named moment	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Kept what matters	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
One next step	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Repaired	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

When more support is needed

Use local safeguarding and incident procedures. Persistent distress, online harm or safety concerns need context-specific support.